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Q1. How does shifting from “rights” to “responsibilities” change policy, practice, and personal behavior?

Answer: Food sovereignty is the right of people to control their own food systems through sustainable, local, and culturally appropriate production, distribution, preservation and consumption. The “right” of the food involves land and water resource management. To uphold this right, it must be transformed into responsibilities. These “responsibilities” include crop cultivation, food production, food processing, and food consumption. In essence, converting this right into responsibilities includes the entire process from land management to the final outcome.

This transformation from rights to responsibilities brings changes in policy, practice, and personal behavior. Indigenous and non Indigenous communities provide a clear example. Indigenous people’s food production practices are deeply rooted in tradition. They usually do not rely on advanced technology due to limited access to diversified agricultural knowledge and prefer to live within their own boundaries and with food consumption largely guided by tradition. They prefer raw food rather than processed food. In contrast, non-indigenous communities are used to processed foods, and their entire food consumption process depends heavily on technology and diversified agricultural knowledge. However, these modern practices often result in foods with lower nutritional value. And as these practices vary, so do the preservation techniques. By shifting from rights to responsibilities, policy is shaped through rules, programs, and incentives that support sustainable practices and ensure individuals and communities act responsibly to uphold those rights. This shift also changes practice by promoting sustainable land and water management, supporting local and traditional food production, and guiding responsible food consumption. At the personal level, it encourages behavior that aligns individual actions with collective goals, ensuring that food production and consumption are carried out responsibly. The whole process of shifting right to responsibility influences the policy, practice, personal behaviour of the individuals/community.

We can see how the shifting of rights to responsibility somehow changes personal behavior and practices. In summary, it transforms policy through supportive rules and incentives, shapes practice by encouraging sustainable production and consumption, and influences personal behavior by fostering accountability and mindful choices.